MODERN INDIA I · DAY 2 OF 6 · TEST ON 31 OCT 2026

# British Structure and Constitutional Developments to 1858

When, why, by whom and what it changed, for every system and Act · mind map · comparison tables

Today's 50 questions: about 25 on how the Company ruled Bengal (Dual Government, Hastings, Cornwallis, land revenue systems) and about 25 on the Acts from 1773 to 1858. Every item has the same card: **When, Where, Why, By whom, Key people, Key events, Result, Exam hook**.

**HOW TO USE THIS NOTE (ABOUT 60 MINUTES)**

1. **5 min:** mind map and big picture.
2. **25 min:** Bengal administration and land revenue (clusters 1 and 2).
3. **25 min:** the Acts, in order (cluster 3), with the comparison table.
4. **5 min:** last-minute sheet. Then start the 50 questions.

## 1. The big picture

After Plassey and Buxar the Company ruled Bengal in two steps: first by the **Dual Government** (1765–72) with no responsibility, then by **direct rule** under Hastings and Cornwallis. Parliament stepped in step by step: first to regulate (1773), then to control (1784), then to end the trade monopoly (1813, 1833), and finally to end the Company (1858).

| Stage | What changed | Landmark |
|---|---|---|
| **1765–72** | Company holds revenue; Nawab holds law and order | Dual Government (Clive) |
| **1772–85** | Company takes over administration | Hastings' reforms |

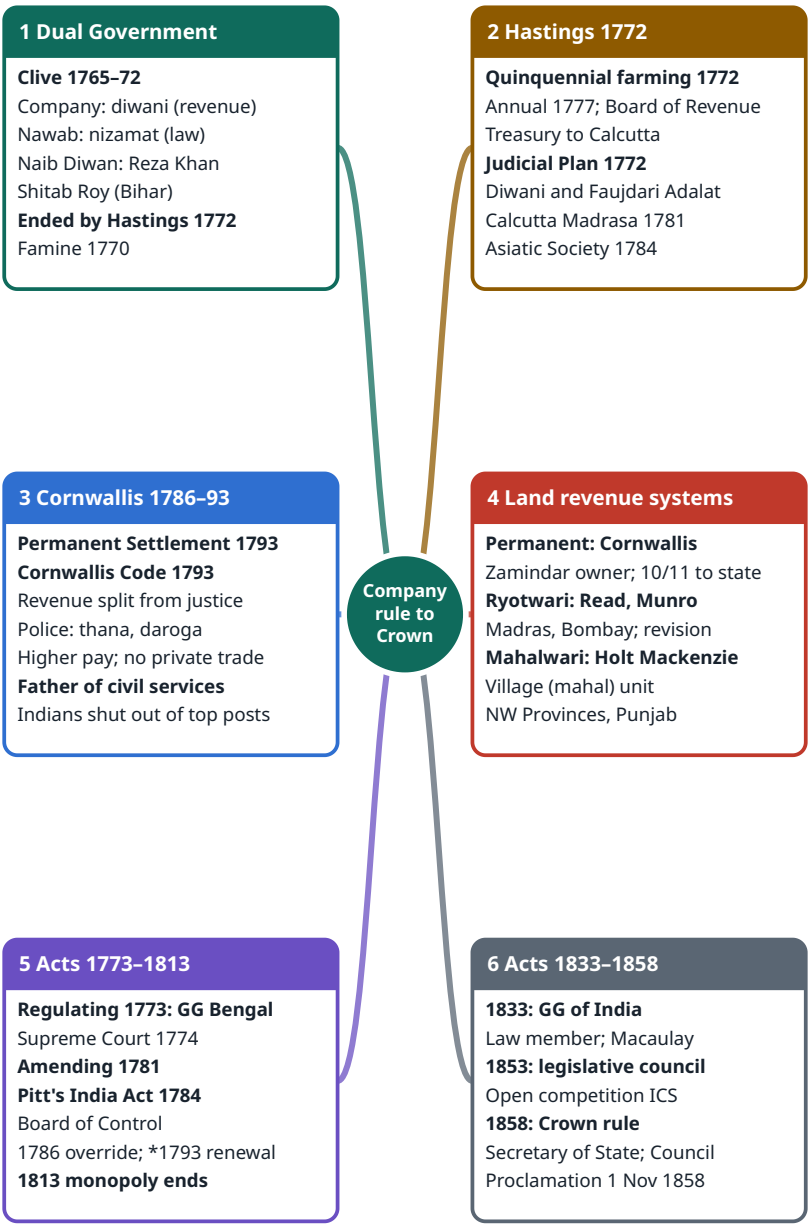
| Stage | What changed | Landmark |
|---|---|---|
| **1773** | First Parliamentary control | Regulating Act |
| **1784** | Government control through a Board | Pitt's India Act |
| **1786–93** | Law, revenue and civil service rebuilt | Cornwallis; Permanent Settlement 1793 |
| **1813–53** | Trade ended; Indian role slowly added | Charter Acts 1813, 1833, 1853 |
| **1858** | Crown takes over | Government of India Act 1858 |

**MEMORY HOOK FOR THE ACTS**

**R-A-P-C-C-C-C-G**: Regulating 1773, Amending 1781, Pitt's 1784, Charter 1793, 1813, 1833, 1853, then Government of India Act 1858.

## 2. Mind map

Read it in 2 minutes.



## 3. Cluster 1: Administration in Bengal

### Dual Government (Clive) — 1765–72

| | |
|---|---|
| **WHEN** | **1765–1772**. |
| **WHERE** | Bengal, Bihar and Orissa. |
| **WHY** | After Diwani (Allahabad 1765), Clive did not want to rule openly because the Company lacked the staff and feared European rivals and Parliament. |
| **BY WHOM** | Clive, working through Indian deputies. |
| **KEY PEOPLE** | • Robert Clive<br>• Muhammad Reza Khan (Naib Diwan of Bengal; deputy Nazim)<br>• Raja Shitab Roy (Naib Diwan of Bihar)<br>• Najm-ud-Daula (Nawab) |
| **KEY EVENTS** | • The Company held the **diwani** (revenue) through the Naib Diwan; the Nawab held the **nizamat** (police, justice) but had no money.<br>• 1770 Bengal famine: about a third of the people died; revenue demand was still pressed. |
| **RESULT** | Power without responsibility for the Company and responsibility without power for the Nawab. Peasants suffered. **Abolished by Warren Hastings in 1772**; Reza Khan and Shitab Roy were arrested and tried. |
| **EXAM HOOK** | Dual Government = Clive (1765–72), ended by Hastings (1772). Naib Diwan = Reza Khan. |

### Warren Hastings: revenue and administration — 1772–85

| | |
|---|---|
| **WHEN** | 1772–85. |
| **WHERE** | Bengal and Calcutta. |
| **WHY** | To end the Dual Government and collect revenue directly; restore the treasury. |
| **BY WHOM** | Hastings with the Council and Board of Revenue. |
| **KEY PEOPLE** | • Warren Hastings<br>• Collectors<br>• Board of Revenue |

| | |
|---|---|
| **KEY EVENTS** | • **1772** the Company took over revenue collection (stood forth as Diwan); treasury moved from Murshidabad to Calcutta; Nawab's allowance cut from Rs 32 lakh to Rs 16 lakh; tribute to the Emperor stopped; Kora and Allahabad sold to Awadh.<br>• **Quinquennial (five-year) farming**: land revenue leased to the highest bidder, 1772; replaced by annual farming in 1777. |
| **RESULT** | The Company ruled Bengal directly. Farming of revenue ruined peasants and led to the Permanent Settlement. |
| **EXAM HOOK** | Revenue farming = Hastings; Permanent Settlement = Cornwallis. |

## Hastings: the Judicial Plan and institutions 1772–91

| | |
|---|---|
| **WHEN** | Judicial Plan 1772; Calcutta Madrasa 1781; Asiatic Society 1784; Benares Sanskrit College 1791. |
| **WHERE** | Districts and Calcutta. |
| **WHY** | To bring law under the Company and to understand Indian law. |
| **BY WHOM** | Hastings (with Impey and Jones). |
| **KEY PEOPLE** | • Warren Hastings<br>• Sir William Jones (Asiatic Society)<br>• Charles Wilkins (Gita translation, 1785)<br>• Jonathan Duncan (Benares Sanskrit College, under Cornwallis) |
| **KEY EVENTS** | • **Diwani Adalat** (civil, under the Collector) and **Faujdari Adalat** (criminal, Qazi and Mufti under the Collector); appeals to the Sadar Diwani and Sadar Nizamat Adalats at Calcutta.<br>• Hindu law for Hindus and Muslim law for Muslims in personal matters.<br>• **1781** Calcutta Madrasa for Muslim law; **1784** Asiatic Society (Jones); **1791** Benares Sanskrit College (Duncan). |
| **RESULT** | The first organised courts under the Company. |
| **EXAM HOOK** | Match: Asiatic Society = Jones; Calcutta Madrasa = Hastings; Benares Sanskrit = Duncan. |

## Nanda Kumar and the impeachment of Hastings 1775–95

| | |
|---|---|
| **WHEN** | 1775 execution; 1787–95 trial. |
| **WHERE** | Calcutta and London. |
| **WHY** | Nanda Kumar accused Hastings of bribery and was then tried for forgery. |
| **BY WHOM** | Sir Elijah Impey (Chief Justice); Burke and Sheridan (prosecutors). |
| **KEY PEOPLE** | • Nanda Kumar<br>• Sir Elijah Impey<br>• Philip Francis<br>• Edmund Burke |
| **KEY EVENTS** | • **1775** Nanda Kumar hanged for forgery by the Supreme Court.<br>• **1787–95** Hastings impeached in the House of Lords. |
| **RESULT** | Hastings was acquitted in 1795. |
| **EXAM HOOK** | Judicial murder charge. First Chief Justice of the Supreme Court = Elijah Impey. |

## Cornwallis: civil service, police and the Code 1786–93

| | |
|---|---|
| **WHEN** | 1786–93 (Code: 1 May 1793). |
| **WHERE** | Bengal. |
| **WHY** | To end corruption and make the Company a proper government. |
| **BY WHOM** | Cornwallis with Shore and Grant. |
| **KEY PEOPLE** | • Lord Cornwallis<br>• John Shore |

| | |
|---|---|
| **KEY EVENTS** | • **Civil service:** higher fixed salaries; ban on private trade and presents; promotion by seniority; Indians kept out of higher posts. He is the "Father of the Civil Services in India".<br>• **Police:** each district divided into thanas of about 20 miles, each under a *daroga*.<br>• **Cornwallis Code 1793:** separated revenue and justice (Collector lost judicial work); district Diwani Adalat under a Judge; Provincial Courts of Appeal (Calcutta, Dacca, Murshidabad, Patna); Sadar Diwani and Sadar Nizamat Adalats; Company servants answerable to courts (rule of law); European courts for English subjects. |
| **RESULT** | Rule of law, but Indians were excluded from top posts. |
| **EXAM HOOK** | Father of civil services = Cornwallis. Separation of powers = Cornwallis Code. |

**QUICK RECALL: CLUSTER 1**

1. Who introduced Dual Government and when? (Clive, 1765)
2. Who ended it? (Hastings, 1772)
3. Who was Naib Diwan of Bengal? (Muhammad Reza Khan)
4. Where did Hastings shift the treasury? (Calcutta)
5. Who is the Father of the Civil Services? (Cornwallis)
6. What did the Cornwallis Code separate? (Revenue and justice)

## 4. Cluster 2: Land revenue systems

| **Permanent Settlement (Zamindari)** | 1793 |
|---|---|
| **WHEN** | **22 March 1793** (Decennial Settlement 1790). |
| **WHERE** | Bengal, Bihar, Orissa, Benares division and the Northern Circars of Madras (about 19% of British India). |
| **WHY** | To fix the state's income, create loyal landlords and encourage investment in land. |
| **BY WHOM** | Cornwallis, with Shore and James Grant. |
| **KEY PEOPLE** | • Cornwallis<br>• John Shore<br>• James Grant |

| | |
|---|---|
| **KEY EVENTS** | • Zamindars became **owners** of land; revenue fixed in perpetuity at about **10/11** of the rent collected (zamindar kept about 1/11).<br>• The **sunset law:** a defaulting zamindar lost his estate by auction.<br>• Peasants became tenants with no rights. |
| **RESULT** | Loyal zamindars, auction of estates, absentee landlords and a poor peasantry; the state could not benefit from rising prices. |
| **EXAM HOOK** | Permanent = Cornwallis, not Ryotwari or Mahalwari areas. Not in Punjab or UP. |

## Ryotwari System — 1792–1820

| | |
|---|---|
| **WHEN** | First tried 1792 (Baramahal); introduced by Munro in Madras from **1820**. |
| **WHERE** | Madras, Bombay, Assam and parts of Berar (about 51% of British India). |
| **WHY** | To collect revenue directly from the cultivator and avoid middlemen. |
| **BY WHOM** | Thomas Munro and Alexander Read. |
| **KEY PEOPLE** | • Alexander Read<br>• Thomas Munro (Governor of Madras 1820–27)<br>• Pringle (Bombay) |
| **KEY EVENTS** | • Peasant (ryot) treated as owner of the land with a right to sell or mortgage.<br>• Revenue assessed on the land, with **periodic revision** (every 20 to 30 years).<br>• Originally about half the produce; later reduced. |
| **RESULT** | Peasants paid very high rents and were forced into debt; the state kept the profits of rising prices. |
| **EXAM HOOK** | Ryotwari = Read and Munro. Largest area of British India. |

## Mahalwari System — 1822–33

| | |
|---|---|
| **WHEN** | **1822** Regulation VII; 1833 Regulation IX. |

| | |
|---|---|
| **WHERE** | North-West Provinces, Punjab and Central Provinces (about 30% of British India). |
| **WHY** | To collect from the village community where land was held jointly. |
| **BY WHOM** | Holt Mackenzie, with Robert Merttins Bird and James Thomason. |
| **KEY PEOPLE** | • Holt Mackenzie<br>• Robert Merttins Bird<br>• James Thomason |
| **KEY EVENTS** | • The **mahal** (village or estate) was the unit.<br>• The village headman (lambardar) collected on behalf of the community.<br>• Revenue revised every 30 years. |
| **RESULT** | Better than the Permanent Settlement but pushed the demand high. |
| **EXAM HOOK** | Mahalwari = Holt Mackenzie. |

## The three systems side by side

| Point | Permanent | Ryotwari | Mahalwari |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Year** | 1793 | 1820 (Madras) | 1822 |
| **By** | Cornwallis | Read and Munro | Holt Mackenzie |
| **Owner** | Zamindar | Ryot (peasant) | Village community |
| **Revision** | Never (permanent) | Every 20–30 years | About every 30 years |
| **Area** | About 19% | About 51% | About 30% |
| **Region** | Bengal, Bihar, Orissa, Benares | Madras, Bombay, Assam | NW Provinces, Punjab, Central Provinces |

**QUICK RECALL: CLUSTER 2**

1. Which system was permanent? (Zamindari, 1793, Cornwallis)
2. Who introduced the Ryotwari? (Read and Munro)
3. Who devised the Mahalwari? (Holt Mackenzie)
4. What share did the zamindar keep? (About 1/11)
5. Which system covered the largest area? (Ryotwari)
6. Which regions were not under the Permanent Settlement? (Punjab, UP, interior Madras)

## 5. Cluster 3: The Acts, 1773 to 1858

### Regulating Act — 1773

| | |
|---|---|
| **WHEN** | Passed 1773; effective 1774. |
| **WHERE** | Parliament; Calcutta. |
| **WHY** | Company misrule, the 1770 famine and bankruptcy. |
| **BY WHOM** | Lord North's government. |
| **KEY PEOPLE** | • Lord North<br>• Warren Hastings<br>• Elijah Impey<br>• Clavering, Monson, Barwell, Francis |
| **KEY EVENTS** | • Governor of Bengal became **Governor-General of Bengal** with a Council of four (majority rule).<br>• Bombay and Madras were subordinated to Bengal.<br>• **Supreme Court** at Calcutta (1774) with a Chief Justice and three judges.<br>• Ban on private trade and gifts.<br>• Court of Directors: four-year terms. |
| **RESULT** | First Parliamentary control, but conflict arose between the Governor-General and the Council. |
| **EXAM HOOK** | Regulating Act = first GG of Bengal (Hastings) and Supreme Court. |

### Amending Act (Act of Settlement) — 1781

| | |
|---|---|
| **WHEN** | 1781. |

| | |
|---|---|
| **WHERE** | Parliament. |
| **WHY** | To fix flaws of the 1773 Act: conflict between the Court and the Council. |
| **BY WHOM** | Parliament. |
| **KEY PEOPLE** | • Warren Hastings<br>• Elijah Impey |
| **KEY EVENTS** | • Governor-General and Council exempted from the Supreme Court for acts in their official capacity.<br>• Court no longer to hear revenue matters.<br>• Hindu and Muslim law for natives.<br>• Appeals from provincial courts to the GG in Council. |
| **RESULT** | Cleared the conflict between Court and Council. |
| **EXAM HOOK** | Amending 1781 = Court limited. |

## Pitt's India Act — 1784

| | |
|---|---|
| **WHEN** | 1784. |
| **WHERE** | Parliament. |
| **WHY** | To increase government control after Fox's India Bill failed. |
| **BY WHOM** | William Pitt the Younger. |
| **KEY PEOPLE** | • William Pitt<br>• Fox<br>• Dundas |
| **KEY EVENTS** | • **Board of Control** (six commissioners: Chancellor of the Exchequer, a Secretary of State and four Privy Councillors) supervised civil and military work.<br>• Court of Directors kept patronage and trade (**dual control**).<br>• Governor-General's Council reduced to **three**.<br>• Bombay and Madras subordinated further.<br>• Company's territory declared "British possessions in India". |
| **RESULT** | Government control began; dual control lasted until 1858. |
| **EXAM HOOK** | Pitt's India Act = Board of Control and dual control. |

## Act of 1786 and Charter Act of 1793

1786, 1793

| | |
|---|---|
| **WHEN** | 1786; 1793. |
| **WHERE** | Parliament. |
| **WHY** | To give Cornwallis the power to override his Council. |
| **BY WHOM** | Parliament. |
| **KEY PEOPLE** | • Cornwallis |
| **KEY EVENTS** | • **1786:** Governor-General could override his Council in special cases and also became Commander-in-Chief.<br>• **1793:** Company's charter renewed for 20 years; overriding power extended to the Governors of Madras and Bombay; members of the Board of Control to be paid from Indian revenues. |
| **RESULT** | Strong executive. |
| **EXAM HOOK** | Override power = 1786. |

## Charter Act of 1813

1813

| | |
|---|---|
| **WHEN** | 1813. |
| **WHERE** | Parliament. |
| **WHY** | To end the Company's monopoly after the French Wars and rising English industry. |
| **BY WHOM** | Parliament. |
| **KEY PEOPLE** | • Lord Minto<br>• Hastings (Moira) |
| **KEY EVENTS** | • **Company's monopoly ended** except in tea and the China trade.<br>• Rs **1 lakh** a year for Indian education and learned Indians.<br>• Christian missionaries allowed.<br>• Territorial and commercial accounts kept separate.<br>• Crown sovereignty over Company territory asserted.<br>• Renewed for 20 years. |
| **RESULT** | First step towards state responsibility for education. |

| | |
|---|---|
| **EXAM HOOK** | Charter 1813 = Rs 1 lakh education grant. |

## Charter Act of 1833

1833

| | |
|---|---|
| **WHEN** | 1833. |
| **WHERE** | Parliament. |
| **WHY** | To complete the end of the Company's trade and centralise law. |
| **BY WHOM** | Parliament, with Macaulay in the Council. |
| **KEY PEOPLE** | • William Bentinck<br>• T. B. Macaulay (first Law member) |
| **KEY EVENTS** | • Governor-General of Bengal became **Governor-General of India** (Bentinck first).<br>• Law-making centralised: laws called **Acts**, not Regulations; Governor-General in Council alone could legislate.<br>• A fourth (Law) member added to the Council.<br>• **Law Commission** under Macaulay; it prepared the Indian Penal Code (1837, enacted 1860).<br>• Company's **commercial functions ended**; it became a political body.<br>• **No Indian to be barred from office by religion, birth, descent or colour.** |
| **RESULT** | Centralised government and a promise of equal service that was not kept. |
| **EXAM HOOK** | Charter 1833 = GG of India, Law member, no discrimination. |

## Charter Act of 1853

1853

| | |
|---|---|
| **WHEN** | 1853 (last Charter Act). |
| **WHERE** | Parliament. |
| **WHY** | To prepare for a new system and to reduce the Company's patronage. |
| **BY WHOM** | Parliament. |
| **KEY PEOPLE** | • Dalhousie<br>• Macaulay Committee (1854) |

| | |
|---|---|
| **KEY EVENTS** | • **No fixed period** for the Company's rule: "until Parliament otherwise decides".<br>• Court of Directors reduced from 24 to **18** (6 nominated by the Crown).<br>• Law member made a full member of the Council.<br>• Separate **legislative council** (12 members) for law-making, a model for Parliament.<br>• **Open competition** for the Civil Service; patronage ended. |
| **RESULT** | Opened the Civil Service to Indians in theory. |
| **EXAM HOOK** | Charter 1853 = no fixed period and open competition. |

## Government of India Act and Queen's Proclamation 1858

| | |
|---|---|
| **WHEN** | **Act: Aug 1858**; Proclamation: **1 Nov 1858**. |
| **WHERE** | Parliament; Allahabad. |
| **WHY** | After the Revolt of 1857, Crown took over the Company. |
| **BY WHOM** | Parliament; Queen Victoria; Canning read the Proclamation at Allahabad. |
| **KEY PEOPLE** | • Lord Stanley (first Secretary of State)<br>• Lord Canning (first Viceroy)<br>• Queen Victoria |
| **KEY EVENTS** | • **Company ended**; Board of Control and Court of Directors abolished.<br>• **Secretary of State for India** with a Council of 15 (the Council of India).<br>• Governor-General became **Viceroy** (Canning first).<br>• **Proclamation:** no more annexations; rights of princes respected; religious tolerance; equal treatment under law; pardon for rebels except those who murdered. |
| **RESULT** | Crown rule until 1947; a new administrative structure. |
| **EXAM HOOK** | 1858 = Crown rule, Secretary of State, Viceroy. |

**QUICK RECALL: CLUSTER 3**

1. Who was the first GG of Bengal? (Hastings, 1773)
2. Which Act created the Supreme Court at Calcutta? (Regulating)
3. What did Pitt's India Act create? (Board of Control)
4. Which Act ended the trade monopoly? (1813 except tea and China; 1833 ended trade fully)
5. Which Act made the GG of India? (1833)
6. Which Act had no fixed period? (1853)
7. Who was the first Viceroy? (Canning)

## 6. The Acts at a glance

| Act | Year | Main provision |
|---|---|---|
| **Regulating** | 1773 | GG of Bengal; four-member Council; Supreme Court |
| **Amending** | 1781 | Limits Supreme Court; official acts exempt |
| **Pitt's India Act** | 1784 | Board of Control; dual control; Council of 3 |
| **Act of 1786** | 1786 | GG overrides Council; also C-in-C |
| **Charter** | 1793 | Renewed 20 years; override extended |
| **Charter** | 1813 | Monopoly ends except tea and China; Rs 1 lakh education |
| **Charter** | 1833 | GG of India; Law member; trade ends; no discrimination |
| **Charter** | 1853 | No fixed period; open competition; legislative council |
| **GoI Act** | 1858 | Crown rule; Secretary of State; Viceroy |

**WRONG STATEMENTS UPSC LIKES**

- Hastings introduced the Permanent Settlement. (No: Cornwallis.)
- The Regulating Act made the first Governor-General of India. (No: of Bengal.)
- The Charter Act of 1833 introduced open competition. (No: 1853.)
- The 1813 Act ended the entire Company trade. (No: except tea and China.)
- Ryotwari gave permanent rights to zamindars. (No.)
- The Dual Government was Hastings' invention. (No: Clive.)
- The Board of Control was created by the Regulating Act. (No: Pitt's 1784.)
- Queen's Proclamation was read at Delhi. (No: Allahabad.)

## 7. Master timeline

- **1765** Diwani; Dual Government begins
- **1772** Dual Government ends; Judicial Plan; revenue farming
- **1773** Regulating Act
- **1781** Amending Act; Calcutta Madrasa
- **1784** Pitt's India Act; Asiatic Society
- **1786** Act of 1786
- **1793** Permanent Settlement; Cornwallis Code; Charter Act
- **1813** Charter Act
- **1820** Ryotwari (Madras)
- **1822** Mahalwari
- **1833** Charter Act
- **1853** Charter Act
- **1858** Government of India Act; Proclamation

Sources: Spectrum, *A Brief History of Modern India*; M. Laxmikanth, *Indian Polity* (Historical Background); Bipan Chandra; standard coaching notes; question set T3-02. Written in my own words. Dates for minor items vary slightly between books.